Her Heart (from Almost, Maine)

By John Cariani

INTRODUCTION

ACTRESS: *It is a cold Friday night in the middle of winter in a small, mythical town in northern Maine called Almost, Maine.*

ACTOR: *Glory is standing in the front yard of an old farmhouse, clutching a small brown paper grocery bag to her chest and looking up at the sky.*

ACTRESS: *A porch light comes on. We hear a screen door open and slam as East enters. He watches Glory for a while.*

ACTOR: *A field of stars – a clear, cold, moonless northern night sky – serves as the backdrop for*

TOGETHER: *Almost, Maine by John Cariani*

HER HEART

EAST: Hello.

GLORY: *(To him.)* Hello. *(Resumes looking to the sky.)*

EAST: I thought I saw someone. *(Little beat.)* I was about to go to bed. I saw you from my window . . . *(Beat.)* Can I - ? . . . Is there something I can do for you?

GLORY: *(To him.)* Oh, no. I'm just here to see the northern lights. *(Back to the sky.)*

EAST: Okay. Okay. It's just – it's awful late and you're in my yard . . .

GLORY: Oh, I hope you don't mind! I'll only be here tonight. I'll see them tonight. The northern lights. And then I'll be gone. I hope you don't mind –

EAST: *(Looking out.)* Is that your tent? *(The tent should be seen by East and Glory – not by the audience.)*

GLORY: Yes.

EAST: You've pitched a tent . . . In my yard . . .

GLORY: So I have a place to sleep, after I see them, I hope you don't mind.

EAST: Well, it's not that I –

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GLORY: Oh, no, I think you mind!

EAST: No, it's not that I mind –

GLORY: No, you do! You do! Oh, I'm so sorry! I didn't think you would! I didn't think -- You see, it says in your brochure

EAST: My brochure?

GLORY: That people from Maine wouldn't mind. It says *(Pulling out a brochure about Maine tourism.)* that people from Maine are different, that they live life "the way life should be," and that, "in the tradition of their brethren in rural northern climes, like Scandinavia," that they'll let people who are complete strangers like cross-country skiers and bikers and hikers, camp out in their yard, if they need to, for nothing, they'll just let you. I'm a hiker. It is true?

EAST: Well –

GLORY: That they'll just let you stay in their yards if you need to? 'Cause I need to. Camp out. 'Cause I'm where I need to be. This is the farthest I've ever traveled – I'm from a part of the country that's a little closer to things – never been this far north before, or east, and did you know that Maine is the only state in the country that's attached to only one other state?!?

EAST: Um –

GLORY: It is!! *(Taking in all the open space.)* Feels like the end of the world, and here I am at the end of the world, and I have nowhere to go, so I was counting on staying here, unless it's not true, I mean is it true?

EAST: Well –

GLORY: Would you let a hiker who was where she needed to be just camp out in your yard for free? I mean, if a person really needed to, really really needed to?

EAST: Well, if a person really needed to, sure, but –

GLORY: *(Huge relief!)* Oh, I'm so glad, then! Thank you! *(She goes to East, throw her arms open, and hugs him. In the hug, the bag gets squished between their bodies. When*

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they part, East is holding Glory's bag. The exchange of the bag is almost imperceptible to both of them, and to the audience. Immediately after hugging East, Glory resumes looking intently for the northern lights. Beat. Then, realizing she doesn't have her bag:) Oh, my gosh! *(Realizing that East has her bag.)* I need that!

EAST: Oh. Here. *(He gives it back.)*

GLORY: Thank you. *(She resumes looking to the sky.)*

EAST: Sure. *(Beat.)* Okay -- Okay . . . *(Beat.)* So you're just lookin' for a place to see the northern lights from?

GLORY: Yeah. Just tonight.

EAST: Well, you know, you might not see 'em tonight, 'cause . . . you never really know -

GLORY: Oh, no. I'll see them. Because I'm in a good place: Your latitude is good. And this is the right time: Solar activity is at an eleven-year peak. Everything's in order. And boy, you have good sky for it. *(Taking in the sky.)* There's lots of sky here.

EAST: Used to be a potato farm.

GLORY: I was gonna say – no trees in the way. And it's flat! Makes for a big sky! *(Beat.)* So – you're a farmer?

EAST: No. Used to be a farmer. I'm a repairman. Fix things.

GLORY: Oh. *(Laughs.)*

EAST: What?

GLORY: You're not a lobster man . . . I guess I thought that everyone from Maine was a lobster man and talked in that funny . . . way like they do in Maine, and you don't talk that way . . .

EAST: Nope. You're not Down East. You're up north. And this is how we talk up north, pretty much. Plus, ocean's a couple hundred miles away. Be an awful long ride to work if I was a lobster man.

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GLORY: *(Enjoying him.)* Yeah. Well, anyway, thank you. Thank you for letting me stay. I've had a bad enough time of things lately not to be given a bad time here –

(East, inexplicably drawn to her, kisses Glory. When they break, the bag has exchanged clutches imperceptibly – East has it. And now we have two stunned people.)

EAST: Oh …

GLORY: *(Trying to figure out what just happened.)* Um …

EAST: Oh, boy.

GLORY: Um …

EAST: I'm sorry. I just -- . . . I think I love you.

GLORY: Really.

EAST: *(Perplexed.)* Yeah. I saw you from my window and . . . I love you.

GLORY: Well . . . -- that's very nice -- . . . but there's something I think you should know: I'm not here for that.

EAST: Oh, no! I didn't think you were!

GLORY: I'm here to pay my respects. To my husband.

EAST: Oh –

GLORY: Yeah: My husband. Wes. I just wanted to say goodbye to him, 'cause he died recently. On Tuesday, actually, and, see, the northern lights – did you know this? – the northern lights are really the torches that the recently departed carry with them so they can find their way to heaven, and see, it takes three days for a soul to make its way home, to heaven, and this is Friday! This is the third day, so, you see, I will see them, the northern lights, because they're him: He'll be carrying one of the torches. And, see, I didn't leave things well with him, so I was just hoping I could come here and say goodbye to him and not be bothered, but what you did there just a second ago, that bothered, me, I think, and I'm not here for that, so maybe I should go . . . and find another yard –

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EAST: No! No! I'm sorry if I -- . . . if I've behaved in a way that I shouldn't have -

GLORY: *(Leaving.)* No . . . I think –

EAST: No! I really don't know what happened.

GLORY: Well, I do, I know what happened!

EAST: I'm not the kind of person who does things like that. Please. Don't go. Just – do what you need to do. I won't bother you. Maybe just . . . consider what I did a very warm Maine welcome.

GLORY: *(Stopping; charmed.)* All right. All right. *(Beat.)* I'm -- My name's Glory.

EAST: I'm East. For Easton. It's the name of the town – little ways that way – where I was born. Mess-up on the birth certificate . . . "a son, Easton, born on this sixth day of January, *[insert year]* in the town of Matthew, Maine" . . . instead of the other way around . . .

GLORY: *(Amused.)* Aw, I'm sorry . . . so, *(Referring to the place.)* Easton, yeah! I passed through near there on my way here, and, by the way, *(Scanning the horizon.)* where is "here," where am I? I couldn't find it on my map.

EAST: Um . . . Almost.

GLORY: What?

EAST: You're in unorganized territory. Township Thirteen, Range Seven. *(Glory checks her map.)* It's not gonna be on your map, cause it's not an actual town, technically.

GLORY: What do you mean –

EAST: See, to be a town, you gotta get organized. And we never got around to gettin' organized, so . . . we're just Almost.

GLORY: Oh . . . *(They enjoy this. Beat. Glory now deals with the fact that she is missing her bag. She was clutching it to her chest, and now it's gone. This should upset her so much that is seems like it affects her breathing.)* Oh! Oh!

EAST: What? What's wrong?

GLORY: *(Seeming to be having trouble breathing.)* My heart!

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EAST: What? Are you okay?

GLORY: My heart! *(Seeing that he has her bag; pointing to the bag.)*

EAST: What?

GLORY: You have my heart! In that bag, it's in that bag!

EAST: Oh.

GLORY: Please give it back . . . please! It's my heart. I need it. Please!

EAST: Okay, okay, okay. *(He gives her the bag.)*

GLORY: Thank you. *(Her breathing normalizes.)*

EAST: You're welcome. *(A long beat while East considers what he has just heard.)* I'm sorry, did you just say that … your heart is in that bag?, is that what you just said?, that . . . your heart -- . . . ?

GLORY: Yes.

EAST: *(Considers.)* It's heavy.

GLORY: Yes.

EAST: *(Beat.)* Why is it in that bag?

GLORY: It's how I carry it around.

EAST: Why?

GLORY: It's broken.

EAST: What happened?

GLORY: Wes broke it.

EAST: Your husband?

GLORY: Yeah, He went away.

EAST: Oh.

GLORY: With someone else.

EAST: Oh, I'm sorry.

GLORY: Yeah. And when he did that, I felt like my heart would break. And that's exactly what happened. It broke: hardened up and cracked in two. Hurt so bad, I had

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to go to the hospital, and when I got there, they told me they were gonna have to take it out. And when they took it out, they dropped it on the floor and it broke into nineteen pieces. Slate. *(Gently shakes the bag)* It turned to slate. *(Beat. She look back up at the sky.)*

EAST: *(Takes this in. Beat. His only response to what she has just told him is:)* Great for roofing. *(Glory just looks at East. Beat. Then:)* Wait a second, how do you breathe? If your heart is in that bag, how are you alive?

GLORY: *(Indicating the heart that's now in her chest.)* Artificial . . .

EAST: Really.

GLORY: Yeah. 'Cause my real one's broken.

EAST: Then – why do you carry it around with you?

GLORY: It's my heart.

EAST: But it's broken.

GLORY: Yeah.

EAST: 'Cause your husband left you.

GLORY: Yeah.

EAST: Well, why are you paying your respects to him if he left you?

GLORY: Because that's what you do when a person dies, you pay them respects –

EAST: But he left you,

GLORY: Yeah, but –

EAST: and it seems to me that a man who leaves somebody doesn't deserve any respects.

GLORY: *(Deflecting.)* Well, I just didn't leave things well with him,

EAST: *(Pressing.)* What do you mean? –

GLORY: and I need to apologize to him.

EAST: But he left you!

GLORY: I know, but I –

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EAST: Why should you apologize?

GLORY: Because!

EAST: Because why?!?

GLORY: Because I killed him!

EAST: Oh. *(This stops East; he backs off a bit.)*

GLORY: And I'd like to apologize. *(Beat. Then, admission:)* See, he had come to visit me when I was in recovery from when they put my artificial heart in – I was almost better; I was just about to go home, too – and he said he wanted me back. And I said, "Wes, I have a new heart now. I'm sorry . . . It doesn't want you back . . . " And that just killed him.

EAST: *(Relief.)* Oh. But, it didn't kill him, you didn't kill him –

GLORY: Yes, I did! Because he got so sad that my new heart didn't want him back, that he just tore outta the hospital, and . . . an ambulance that was comin' in from an emergency didn't see him and just . . . took him right out, and if I'd have been able to take him back,

EAST: Glory –

GLORY: he wouldn't have torn outta there like that,

EAST: Glory!

GLORY: and been just taken out like that, and so, I just feel that, for closure, the right thing to do is *(Inexplicably drawn to her, East kisses Glory. When she pulls away, he has her heart again. She takes it back.)* Please don't do that anymore.

EAST: Why? I love you!

GLORY: Well, don't.

EAST: Why?

GLORY: Because I won't be able to love you back: I have a heart that can pump my blood and that's all. The one that does the other stuff is broken. It doesn't work anymore. *(Again, inexplicably drawn to her, East deliberately kisses Glory. Glory*

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pulls away. East has her heart again. Glory grabs it from him; East grabs it right back.)

EAST: Please let me have this.

GLORY: *(Desperately trying to get her heart back.)* No! It's mine!

EAST: *(Keeping her heart.)* I can fix it!

GLORY: I don't know if I want you to!

EAST: Glory -- ?

GLORY: *(Going after her heart.)* East, please give that back to me!

EAST: *(Keeping her heart.)* But, it's broken.

GLORY: Please -- !

EAST: It's no good like this.

GLORY: But, it's my heart, East!

EAST: Yes, it is. And I believe I have it. *(This stops Glory. Beat.)* And I can fix it. *(Beat.)* I'm a repairman. I repair things. It's what I do. *(Beat. East crouches, gently places the bag on the ground and start to open it in order to examine its contents. As he opens the bag, music up, and the northern lights appear – in front of Glory, above Glory, on the field of stars behind Glory. Glory sees them … and they're a thing of wonder.)*

GLORY: Oh! Oh, wow! Oh, they're so beautiful . . . *(Remembering who they are.)* Oh! Oh! -- Wes!! Wes!! Goodbye! I'm so sorry! . . . Goodbye, Wes! *(And the northern lights – and Wes – are gone. Glory turns to East, who has taken a little piece of her heart out of the bag is examining it. Then:)* Hello, East. *(East looks at Glory, and then begins repairing her heart.)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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